

A Face in a Million

Ybor City in Tampa in the US is using a facial recognition system to track down criminals despite severe protests by residents concerned about misuse of this technology to invade the privacy of individuals. This technology was also used at Superbowl XXV, one of America's biggest sporting events.

This technology compares 80 nodal points on the face with images stored in a database. This kind of spying is more reliable for identification than other methods of biometrics such as iris scanning, and finger print scanning, which have to be done with the user's knowledge. Facial recognition is accurate because every face has its own unique characteristics, the same as fingerprints. All that is needed is a hidden camera to capture images of people. The comparison takes only 5-10 seconds to complete and you are notified if there is at least an 85 per cent match.

Think of it this way: people with evil intentions can pick you out even in a crowd within 5 to 10 seconds and you won't even come to know of it. Are the days of having a quiet walk by yourself gone?

board or a wireless LAN card can take a look at your home or company data.

Making the connex-ion

Whacking is not limited to just listening to signals from the wireless network. Signals can also be picked up from wireless equipment. For instance, many of the wireless keyboards available today make use of a transmitter/receiver arrangement for data communication. These keyboards do not have any unique connection code for each unit. This means someone else using the same model with modifications to extend the range of his keyboard can look at what you are doing and even gain control of your PC.

So if you are the proud owner of a wireless keyboard, take care! There might be someone watching every single letter you type.

Even the radiation from your computer's monitor could be reconstructed to see what you are up to. TEMPEST is a technology that allows a hacker to do this and more. Using this technology, it is possible to spy on information transmitted by satellite, microwave signals and radio signals. And that includes cellular phones as well. The spy can be located even a couple of kilometres away and yet listen or see what you are up to.

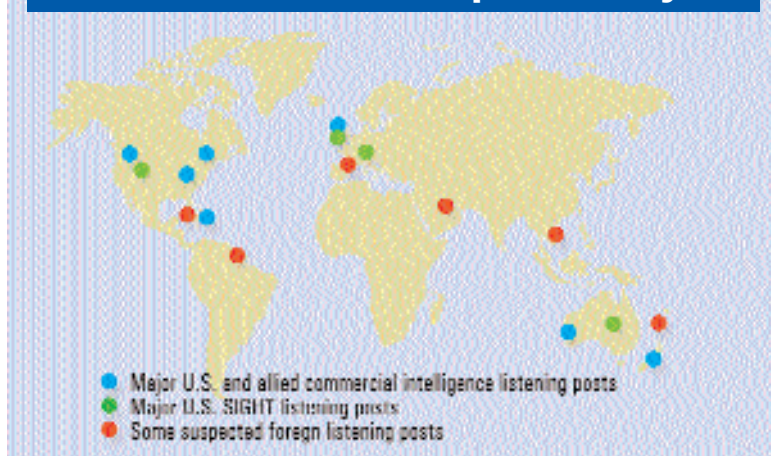
The technology used in TEMPEST makes use of the fact that all electronic devices emit electromagnetic radiation. Much of the radiation that a device emits may be due to a certain task it is doing at that particular instance. This technology intercepts the radiation and converts it into a form that a human can understand.

For instance, in order to pry into a particular computer, all that needs to be done is to lock on to the frequency of emissions and process it line by line to see what's happening on the screen. In fact, it is possible to reconstruct what is happening on a computer screen from about 1 km away.

Even reconstruction of what is stored in the target PC's memory and hard disk is possible. However, the spy has to be closer to the target to be able to do this. To add to all of this, you cannot detect a person using TEMPEST to spy on you as the only thing he does is listen in.

Originally developed by the US government's

Echelon Network: Suspected Layout



NSA (National Security Agency), TEMPEST has been around since the 1950s. TEMPEST equipment is available in the US and although exports outside the US are prohibited, there's no way to determine if smuggled units are available outside the US or not.

Echelon—spying unlimited

But TEMPEST is way behind when it comes to spying technologies as compared to Echelon. The latter is a spying network and is of great concern to people in all fields—industrial, military, or individual. Echelon can intercept as many as 3 billion communications everyday. It can spy on phone calls, faxes, e-mails, downloads, microwave, cellular, satellite communications—the list goes on.

Started way back in 1947, Echelon is operated by the intelligence agencies of five countries—the US, the UK, Canada, Australia and New Zealand. The US government, however, has not yet acknowledged the existence of this network. It was only after Australia and New Zealand acknowledged its existence that the general public got to know that Echelon is not a figment of some writer's imagination in a spy thriller.

Originally developed purely for military espionage, it is now believed that Echelon is used for spying on organisations, businesses and individuals. One of the primary ways it operates is via ground-based radio antennae and satellites to spy on satellite transmissions.

It is believed that Echelon is also capable of being used for live tapping of cables in several places. Internet communication is intercepted using 'sniffer' devices at key junctions of the Net. All the data collected by these various means are then run through powerful computers, which scan them for important data. 'Dictionary' is the term used to denote these computers that search

